How to Talk to Kids About Homelessness



A simple, honest guide for the adults in a child's life who want to help kids grow into compassionate, aware, and empathetic people.

It usually starts with a question.



You're walking to the car after grocery shopping. Or sitting at a red light. And a child you love points to someone sitting outside and asks, **"Why is he sleeping there?"**

Your stomach tightens. You want to say the right thing. You don't want to scare them. You don't want to oversimplify. You're not even sure you fully understand it yourself.

So maybe you change the subject. Or say, "I'll explain later." Or offer something quick and move on.

That moment—the hesitation, the uncertainty—is something almost every parent knows. And it makes sense. These are complicated, layered realities. There's no perfect script.

But here's what we want you to know before you read another page: **You don't have to have the perfect answer. You just have to be willing to try.**

And the fact that you downloaded this guide means you already are.

what kids learn in this moment stays with them.



You know this: Children are always learning—not just in classrooms, but in parking lots and car rides and quiet moments when they think we're not paying attention.

Every time a child notices something about the world and looks to a trusted adult for a response, they're learning how to interpret what they see.

When it comes to homelessness, that moment matters more than we might realize. **Kids are forming three things at once:**

Empathy
Do people who are struggling deserve care and dignity?

Language
How do we talk about people who are different from us?

Worldview
Is this something that happens to "other" people, or is it part of our shared community?

Silence teaches something, too. Deflection teaches something. So does a quick, dismissive answer. None of those are wrong—engaging kids is hard, and we're all doing our best.

But when we take even a small moment to engage honestly, we give children something they'll carry for a long time: the ability to see people.

That's what this guide is for.

Keep it simple. Keep it honest.

Knowing what to say and how to say it is hard. We get it. The good news: Kids don't need the full picture right away. They need an honest, age-appropriate answer that leaves room for more conversation over time.

"That person doesn't have a home right now. Some people go through really hard times."

"We don't always know someone's whole story, but we know they deserve kindness."

"It makes me feel sad, too. It's okay to feel that way."

Young kids (ages 4–7)

At this age, children think in concrete terms. Keep it simple and grounded in what they can see and understand.

For older kids & teens, see the next page

Older kids (ages 8–12)

Kids this age can handle a little more nuance. They're starting to ask "why" and think about fairness.

"It's not usually because someone made one bad choice. It's usually a lot of hard things happening at once."

"Homelessness can happen for a lot of different reasons: losing a job, getting sick, or not having family nearby to help."

"There are people and organizations working every day to help."

"How do you think they're feeling right now?"

"what do you think it would take to actually solve this problem?"

Teens (ages 13-18)

Teenagers can engage with complexity, systems, and justice. Invite them into the conversation rather than lecturing them.

"Did you know that a lot of families with kids experience homelessness? It's not always what we picture."

"what do you think when you see someone experiencing homelessness?"

Words matter more than you think.

The language we use around homelessness shapes how children understand it—and how they'll talk about it for the rest of their lives. A few small shifts can make a big difference.

Instead of this:	Try this:
"Homeless people"	"People experiencing homelessness"
"A bum"	"Someone who doesn't have a home right now"
"They made bad choices"	"Some people go through really hard times"
"You shouldn't look at them"	"Everyone deserves care and respect"
"They should just get a job"	"We don't know their whole story"

Here are a few guiding principles:

Lead with humanity

The person comes before the situation. They are not defined by where they sleep.

Avoid blame

Homelessness is almost never the result of one decision. It's the result of layered, compounding hardship.

Stay curious

Model what it looks like to wonder about someone's story rather than assume.

It's okay to not know.

"I'm not sure, but let's think about it together" is a powerful thing for a child to hear.

See the person, not just the situation.



This is Maria.

She has six kids and lives in Atlanta just like us! She's a really hard worker and a great mom.

It's easy—and human—to see a situation before we see a person. But one of the most powerful things we can teach children is to look a little longer. To wonder. To extend the same dignity to a stranger on the street that they'd want extended to them.

People experiencing homelessness are parents, siblings, coworkers, and neighbors. They have names, histories, and futures. They are not a category. They are not "other." **They're part of our community. Atlanta is their home, too!**

This story is an opportunity to find shared connection points in your own lives:

Maria is a mother of six. She grew up in Georgia, always wanted a family of her own, and built one. For years, she worked full-time, took her kids to pumpkin patches, and made sure they got to school every day.

Then—through a series of losses she never saw coming—she found herself with nowhere to go. She moved from motels to a friend's couch to her car, all while making sure her children never missed a day of school, never saw her fall apart, never lost their sense of being loved.

"I could not fail them," she says. "It was not an option for me."

Maria eventually found her way to Atlanta Mission. She's still there—still in the program, still doing the hard work of healing and rebuilding. But something has already shifted.

"More than a mother, I'm Maria," she says. "And I'm finding out who that is."

Her story isn't finished. It's moving forward. And it started with a door that opened.

"Why don't they just get a job?"

Kids ask honest questions. Here are some of the most common ones—and honest, age-appropriate ways to answer them.

"Why are they homeless?"

"Homelessness can happen for a lot of different reasons. Someone might lose their job, get really sick, or not have family nearby who can help. Sometimes a lot of hard things happen all at once, and it becomes too much for one person to handle alone. It's not usually just one thing."

"Are they dangerous?"

"Most people experiencing homelessness are just people going through a really hard time—the same way anyone might if they lost their home. It's always good to be aware of your surroundings, just like anywhere else. But fear isn't the right starting point. Kindness usually is."

"Can we help them?"

"Yes. And I'm really glad you want to. There are lots of ways to help—big and small. We can talk about some of them together."

"Why don't they just go to a shelter?"

"That's a great question. Shelters help a lot of people, but they're not always easy to get into—sometimes they're full, or a person needs a special kind of help that takes time to find. Organizations like Atlanta Mission work hard to make sure people have a safe place to go and the support they need to rebuild their lives."

"Will that ever happen to us?"

"I understand why you might wonder that. Our family is safe. And if we ever needed help, there would be people to help us. That's actually one reason it matters that we care about others who need help right now—because we're all part of the same community."

What can we do together?





One of the best things about talking to kids about hard things is that it naturally leads to the question: What can we do? And the answer doesn't have to be complicated.

Here are some simple, meaningful ways to turn this conversation into action—together.

Donate items as a family

Many organizations, including Atlanta Mission, accept donations of clothing, hygiene products, and household items. Let your child help pick out items to donate. It makes the act of giving concrete and personal.

Volunteer together

Atlanta Mission and organizations like it often have family-friendly volunteer opportunities. Serving together gives children a chance to see the work up close—and to understand that helping is something ordinary people do, not just organizations.

Practice everyday kindness

Teach kids to make eye contact, smile, and treat everyone with dignity—on the street, in the store, everywhere. Small moments of acknowledgment matter more than we know.

Keep the conversation going

This doesn't have to be a one-time talk. Return to it. Let it evolve as your child grows. The goal isn't a perfect conversation—it's an ongoing one.

You're not alone in this.





For over 100 years, Atlanta Mission has walked alongside neighbors experiencing homelessness in our community. What started as a single shelter has grown into a network of programs designed to meet people where they are—and walk with them toward lasting stability.

Atlanta Mission's approach goes beyond meeting immediate needs. Every neighbor who comes through the door receives access to safe shelter, nutritious meals, counseling, case management, job readiness support, and trauma-informed care. **The goal isn't just to help someone survive—it's to help them rebuild.**

Families. Individuals. Women and children. Atlanta Mission serves them all—with dignity, consistency, and hope.

If this guide has meant something to you, we'd love for you to learn more about the work happening right here in our community.

Learn more:

- **Explore ways to help:** atlantamission.org/ways-to-give
- **Read stories of lives being restored:** atlantamission.org/stories

It doesn't have to be perfect.

Here's what we want you to remember as you close this guide: The goal was never a perfect conversation. It was an honest one.

Kids don't need us to have all the answers. They need us to be willing to sit with hard questions, to model curiosity over judgment, and to show them that the people we pass on the street are worth noticing, worth wondering about, and worth caring for.

That's not a small thing. In fact, it might be one of the most important things you ever teach them.

So the next time a child you love points to someone and asks a hard question, take a breath. You don't have to explain everything. You just have to say something true.

"That person matters. And so does the way we treat them."

That's enough to start.

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